PROGRESSION · TIMELINE · STRUCTURE

cycle

A closed loop of 3-6 stages that returns to its start — for a process with no beginning or end, where the last stage feeds the first.

THE WATER CYCLE

Nothing is spent — only moved.

Evaporation

The sun lifts water from ocean and leaf into vapor.

Condensation

Vapor cools into cloud, a reservoir held aloft.

Precipitation

Rain and snow return the water to the ground.

Collection

Rivers gather it back to the sea, and it begins again.



THE CARBON CYCLE

Six stages is the crowded ceiling.

Photosynthesis

Plants pull carbon from the air into sugar.

Respiration

Living things burn sugar and breathe carbon back.

Decomposition

Decay returns carbon from the dead to the soil.

Combustion

Fire and fuel release stored carbon at once.

Ocean uptake

Seawater absorbs a share of the airborne carbon.

Sedimentation

The slow route locks carbon into stone, and the wheel turns.



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When NOT to reach for cycle.

A linear process

If the sequence has a real start and a real end, use list-steps — the numbered spine promises exactly that order. The cycle's closed loop mis-cues a one-way process as recurring.

More than six stages

Past six the ring crowds and the descriptions shrink below legibility. Keep the six load-bearing stages here and push the detail to list-steps or a second slide.

Parallel options

If the items are alternatives the audience weighs rather than stages that flow into each other, use cards-grid or verdict-grid. The arrows here read as causation, not choice.

RELATED COMPONENTS

See also.

`list-steps` — the process is linear — a real start and finish, not a loop

`timeline-list` — events fixed to dates rather than a repeating cycle

`diagram` — the loop has branches or feedback into non-adjacent stages